

The Glorious King of Tantras, the Garland of the Moon

Śrī Candramālatantrārāja · Toh 395 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ཟ་ལྷའ་ཕིང་བའ་རིན་པོ་ལྷ་པོ་

Toh 395 in the Kangyur is a Vajrayāna tantric scripture known in Sanskrit as the Śrī Candramālatantrārāja and in Tibetan as Dpal Zla ba'i phreng ba'i rgyud kyi rgyal po, rendered in English as The Glorious King of Tantras, the Garland of the Moon. It belongs to the class of Buddhist tantric texts and takes the form of a dialogue in which a disciple addresses Vajrasattva, the vajra-bearing lord, with questions concerning the nature and measure of the twenty-four lamps and the abiding of what is established by intrinsic nature. The Blessed One's response unfolds as instruction on tantric practice, including contemplation of the guru's grace and the examination of practice in charnel grounds and similar conducive settings. The text was translated into Tibetan by Ma Tsamdamala and the monk Śākya Yeshe, and it is preserved among the tantric scriptures of the Kangyur.

Translated by Ma Tsamdamala and the monk Śākya Yeshe.

In the language of India: Śrī Candramālatantrārāja. In the language of Tibet:
The Glorious King of Tantras, the Garland of the Moon.

Homage to the Glorious Vajrasattva.

Kye ho! O Lord who bears the vajra,
regarding the twenty-four lamps,
what are their definitive natures, what are their measures,
and how does what is established by intrinsic nature abide?
O Protector, please explain this to me.

The Blessed One then declared:

One who desires to accomplish what is established by intrinsic nature
should well reflect on the grace of the guru,
and in a charnel ground or some such place
that is free from the three hindrances and endowed with good qualities,
examine through investigation the abode of the initial practice.
As for the supreme individual, there is nothing to examine;
one takes one's seat in a place endowed with good qualities.
The yogin who takes up the unsurpassed mind
examines the measure of leisure through the three gateways.

By definitively cultivating the three bindings,
it is certain that accomplishment is achieved within a single lifetime.

The breath-binding is the tip of the nose at the conventional level.
The mind-binding is four finger-widths into the element of space.
The consciousness-binding is self-awareness, inconceivable.

From the variety of causes and conditions,
the various aspirations of sentient beings arise.
Through the purity of those three bindings,
sentient beings are definitively liberated from bondage.
This is to be known from the guru's own mouth.

From the part of the three perceptions, liberation comes.
The three subtle aspects of the seminal essence,
arising in the sequence of the five-branched elements,
sound and self-awareness appearing each in turn,
the manner of emptiness, skillful means, and wisdom,
the grounds, the path, and all the successive stages
naturally abiding — the skilled one brings these together.

Then the measures of the lamps are taught.
The measures are both general and particular.
From two hundred and twelve syllables
the definitive measure of the Tantra that Cuts the Secret arises.
One hundred and thirty-five syllables —
from nineteen syllables arises the definitive measure of the Precious Garland.
One hundred and thirty-four,
from thirteen immutable syllables arises
the lamp of body, speech, and mind.
From eighty-five syllables and four,
whatever arises from what is incomplete —
that is the inconceivable secret.
Eighty-two syllables and one —
that is the arising measure of the Blazing Jewel.
Thirty-one syllables,
arising from twenty-two —
that is the measure equal to space.
Sixty-six syllables and six —

that is the measure of the Tantra of the Great Pledge.
Sixty syllables and twenty-one —
renowned as the Secret Vajra.
Sixty-two, the immutable,
sixteen — that is the measure of the Greatly Powerful.
Forty-one syllables and five —
that is the measure of the Great Sky.
Sixty-six syllables and six —
that is the arising measure of the Blazing Gnosis.
Thirty-six syllables and nine —
that is the measure of the Garland of Gnosis.
Thirty-four syllables and twenty-four —
that is the measure of the Secret of the Ḍākinīs.
Thirty-four syllables and forty-four —
that is the measure of the Garland of Fire.
Twenty-two syllables and eighteen —
that is the arising measure of the King of Gnosis.
Seventy-eight syllables and a half foot —
that is the measure of the King of Passion.
Twenty-five verses —
that is the arising measure of the Intention of Gnosis.
Ninety, arising from ninety-eight —
that is the measure of the Secret of Gnosis.
Twenty, whatever that is —
that is the measure of the Secret Vajra King.
One hundred and twenty-two —
that is the measure of the Vajra King Rāli.
Fifty-three syllables and ten —
that is the arising measure of the Charnel Ground Ornament.
Thirty-three syllables —
sixteen — the summary measure of the Ḍākinīs.
Fifty syllables and fifteen —
the arising Secret King of Nectar.
Forty syllables and twenty-four —
that is the standard measure of the Wheel of the Sun.
Thirty syllables and sixteen —
the arising measure of the Garland of the Moon.

Then what is to be definitively explained:
the one who teaches the wheel of secrets —
the pledges of the secret vajra...

The teacher is established as the great pledge.

The great and powerful one who teaches the six adversaries.

The four empowerments, negation and accomplishment — cutting through the secret.

That self-awareness he teaches is inconceivable.

Teaching the three syllables — the Blazing Jewel.

Teaching the path of the three gates — equal to space.

The Blessed One and the rest — beyond doubt.

The teacher is the great sky.

That which teaches the reality of the four empowerments
is established as the tantra of the secret of wisdom.

Whatever wondrous views and conduct have arisen —
the teacher is established as the Garland of Wisdom.

The meaning of the five aspects of the narrative opening
is taught by the tantra of the secret of the ḍākinīs.

That which teaches the glory of Heruka
is known as the tantra of the Garland of Fire.

That which teaches the meaning of the three empowerments
is established as the rāli of body, speech, and mind.

That which teaches the jewel of vessel and contents
is established as the rāli of the Garland of Jewels.

Teaching the co-emergent — contemplate wisdom:
it is the vajra, utterly unsullied.

That which teaches the reality of the deity
is established as the rāli of the King of Desire.

The Vajra King who teaches the five certainties
is known as the Rigi Ārāli.

The Charnel Ground Ornament, teaching the eight charnel grounds.

The pledge and vow of the three ḍākinīs —
the teacher is the Vow of the Ḍākinīs.

That which teaches the six, beginning with the maṇḍala,
is the Secret King of Nectar.

Slaying error along with its ground —
teaching the three is the tantra of the King of Wisdom.

Teaching the definitive without abandonment is the Wheel of the Sun.
Teaching the three — definite measure and accomplishment — is the Garland of the Moon.
Teaching the five — tantra and the rest — is the Blazing Wisdom.
Then all the assembled retinue rejoiced, and in jubilation at the meaning of all the tantras,

Translator's Notes

- The opening colophon names the translators as Ma Tsamdamala and the monk Śākya Yeshe. The rendering of "མ་ཙམ་དམ་ལལ་" as Ma Tsamdamala follows the standard reconstruction of this collaborator's name in Tibetan-Sanskrit translation teams.

The central section enumerating tantras by syllable count is a canonical catalog passage listing individual tantras by their length. The names given are translations of the Tibetan titles as they appear; several may correspond to known Sanskrit tantras but the precise identifications are uncertain without further collation.

The term "མཐོ་མཐོ་མཐོ་" rendered as "the three bindings" refers to a specific yogic technical triad: the binding of breath, the binding of mind, and the binding of consciousness, which the text itself immediately defines. This is a standard Vajrayāna physiological and contemplative framework.

The final line of the passage is clearly a continuation of a larger text and breaks off mid-sentence. No completion is attempted.

- The passage is a technical classification text identifying which tantra teaches which doctrine or practice. The term "rāli" appears as a transliterated Tibetan technical term of uncertain Sanskrit origin (possibly a variant of ḍālinī or a regional tantric term); it has been retained as "rāli" for consistency with the preceding passage. The phrase "Rīgi Ārāli" renders the Tibetan "ri gi ā ra li," which appears to be a proper tantric title retained in transliteration. The final sentence is syntactically incomplete in the source, suggesting the passage continues; this has been rendered naturally as an open sentence.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of

stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.